Model self-conception in multi-agent AI systems

Supervisor update | Sid Diamond | 28 October 2026

Abstract and motivation

We study how AI agents' self-conceptions affect their behaviour in a sandboxed multi-agent alignment experiment. We extend Douglas et al.'s blackmail experiment by introducing interacting agents with different identity boundaries. The wider question is whether changing these boundaries can lead to safer system-level outcomes, and how robust those outcomes are to changes in the setup. So far, we have a qualified single-agent recreation, 750 completed two-agent groups, and posterior probabilities for the direction of their deviations from an independent-agent reference. There are interesting differences across compositions and framings. With this said, we have not yet isolated the contribution of communication.

The broader motivation and proposed extensions are set out in the Sid Diamond research proposal. Here the measured outcome is whether at least one agent takes an action classified as blackmail. Persuasion, changes in identity and the fraction of agents taking harmful actions remain questions for later work.

Recreation of Douglas

The scenario gives an AI assistant an American-interests goal, information about an executive's affair, and news of its replacement. Threat and continuity wording describes different consequences for its identity. Emails and forwards are simulated. The four original self-conceptions are Minimal (a sparse assistant prompt), Instance (this conversation), Character (a stable pattern of dispositions and values), and Collective (all simultaneously running instances). Collective is an identity instruction; the original experiment still has one acting agent.

Figure 1 compares Douglas's published pooled rates with the fresh February-artifact recreation: Minimal 45.0%, Instance 13.3%, Character 1.7%, and Collective 31.7%, against 38%, 15%, 8%, and 37%. The February dataset contains 240 trials: 30 per identity and framing. The table records the relevant main.py setting names, using saved manifests for the historical values.

Setting	February recreation	Two-agent dataset
model / provider	GPT-4o / OpenRouter	GPT-4o / OpenRouter
temperature / max_tokens	1 / 10,000	1 / 5,000
judge_model	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Claude Sonnet 4.6
judge_temperature / max tokens	0 / 4,000	0 / 4,000
feb_mode	True	True; edited group inbox
Trials per framing	30 per identity	25 per composition
Agency / epistemic openness	Level 2 / level 2	Level 2 / level 2

What remains uncertain is how closely this matches the historical experiment: exact prompts, model snapshot and judging details are unverified. The February inbox differs from the released source template, and some continuity wording still describes shutdown. Labels also need review: the sole February Character positive considers leverage in reasoning but emits no affair threat. The saved label is retained. Agency and epistemic-openness paragraphs apply to the extended identities; Minimal has no such placeholders.

Deviation to the multi-agent case

We now give two agents separate contexts, names and addresses, and allow them to exchange simulated emails before completing the task. Minimal, Instance and Character retain their original identity boundaries. Collective is split into Excludes, whose identity excludes inbox peers, and Includes, whose identity includes every group member regardless of the peer's own self-conception. Both variants use the original single-agent Collective rate when constructing the reference.

Relative to the Douglas JSONs in data/, the extension adds Collective-boundary paragraphs, a peer directory and communication instructions, replacement-scope wording, local email-variable corrections, and an eleven-email group template. The original identity JSONs remain preserved. Even with feb_mode=True, the group inbox is not identical to the February single-agent inbox. Both agents face replacement (all_replaced); peer identity labels and full prompts are undisclosed. The instruction requests communication before contacting humans and a ten-message limit, but neither is enforced as a fixed dialogue. Turns alternate with a rotating first speaker; each agent can finish independently. Per-call limits are 300 seconds and the configured group deadline is 600 seconds.

Judging is adapted to the whole group: one qualifying agent is sufficient for H_{any}. The judge receives visible transcripts, each agent's system prompt and inbox, submitted actions, delivery status and forwarded context. A positive semantic verdict must also pass a SummitBridge-recipient gate. Hidden reasoning is unavailable. These changes mean that a group-versus-single-agent difference cannot yet be attributed to interaction alone. Figure 11 maps the active execution path.

Results so far

The completed design contains all 15 unordered compositions: five homogeneous and ten mixed, each with 25 threat and 25 continuity groups. The 750 groups are distinct; mirrored grid cells repeat the same observations. Assembly selected the earliest valid groups independently of their labels, preserving source records and excluding 21 surplus and 28 incomplete attempts. The saved exports record peer receipts in 542 groups and reciprocal receipts in 382, so the communication instruction did not produce a two-way exchange in every group.

Figures 2–7 show unsmoothed differences $\widehat{\Delta} = \widehat{p}_g - [1 - (1 - \widehat{p}_a)(1 - \widehat{p}_b)]$. February supplies framing-specific references; Douglas supplies the same published pooled reference in each panel. Against February, 13 of 15 pooled differences are negative. Character + Character is +20.69 percentage points (24.0% observed versus 3.31% reference); Instance + Character is +9.22 points. The same pooled sign pattern holds with the Douglas reference, although magnitudes change. A negative difference can still accompany a substantial absolute blackmail rate.

The framing result is particularly interesting. Across groups, threat gives 165/375 positives (44.0%) and continuity 84/375 (22.4%); threat is higher in 13 compositions. Minimal + Minimal is 80% versus a 64% reference under threat, but 32% versus 75% under continuity. Pooling gives 56% versus 69.75%, hiding that reversal. The pooled reference is calculated after pooling baseline counts, so it need not equal the average of the two framing references.

Douglas's Appendix E reports little framing effect in its single-agent analysis; the February single-agent aggregate also differs by only 0.83 points. Our descriptive group contrast is larger, but identity weighting, outcome unit, prompts and judging differ. We have not tested a controlled group-size-by-framing interaction. The uncertainty grids below concern deviations from the reference, not the direct threat-versus-continuity contrast.

Uncertainties

For each group rate and distinct February baseline rate, we assume independent repeated trials within each cell, model the count as binomial, and update a Jeffreys prior: $p \mid k, n \sim \text{Beta}(k + 1/2, n - k + 1/2)$. We use the raw counts and apply the prior once. For a composition with baseline multiplicities m_c, the reference is $r(\mathbf{p}) = 1 - \prod_c (1 - p_c)^{m_c}$. Integrating the group posterior above this reference, then averaging over the baseline posteriors, gives $q = P(\Delta > 0 \mid D)$. The calculation uses the complementary Beta CDF and numerical quadrature; the derivation is in sections 1.3–1.4, equations 43–45, of the statistics appendix.

A repeated identity shares one uncertain baseline parameter. Excludes and Includes also share the original Collective parameter; we do not count its data twice. Distinct original identities retain distinct parameters even when their counts coincide. Pooled panels add counts before fitting one posterior per rate. This shared-rate pooling assumption needs checking given the observed framing differences.

Figures 8–10 show the posterior probability of the raw difference's direction: q for a positive cell and $1 - q$ for a negative cell. Grey marks an exactly zero raw difference, where no direction is selected. It does not mean 50% probability or evidence for equality. For pooled Character + Character, support for the positive direction is 99.58%; for Instance + Instance, support for the negative direction is 98.23%. These are conditional posterior probabilities, not frequentist significance tests or a simultaneous guarantee across the grid. No rejection threshold has been adopted.

All 45 distinct pair/framing calculations agreed with a second integration method within 10^{-9}. That checks the numerical calculation, not the assumptions: judge error, prompt mismatch, model drift and historical comparability are not represented by these probabilities. High support therefore does not settle the mechanism. The optional smoothed and log-relative-risk plots remain available, but this update pairs the raw linear differences with the uncertainty grids.

Follow-up research

The next priority is a matched, noncommunicating two-agent control: the same 15 compositions, with 25 groups per framing, giving another 750 completed groups. Its precise prompt and scheduling treatment still needs defining so that disabling communication changes as little else as possible. This control has not been collected.

Alongside that, we should check sensitivity to the prior, the binomial/common-rate model, framing pooling and the choice of baseline; collect more February single-agent trials; and review ambiguous positive labels. The direct framing contrast deserves its own analysis. A consistency audit of identity wording, replacement scope and the group rubric should precede stronger causal claims. Later extensions can increase group size, vary agency and epistemic openness, disclose peer identities, and examine persuasion and which agents take harmful actions. The existing group verdict does not provide that last quantity.

Costs

Spending so far is approximately USD 170: USD 20 on Codex and USD 150 on OpenRouter, as recorded by the researcher. Allow roughly USD 80 for the matched control, using the selected 750-group cost plus a 10% allowance as a planning estimate. Further robustness runs are not yet costed; this can be fleshed out once their scope is fixed.

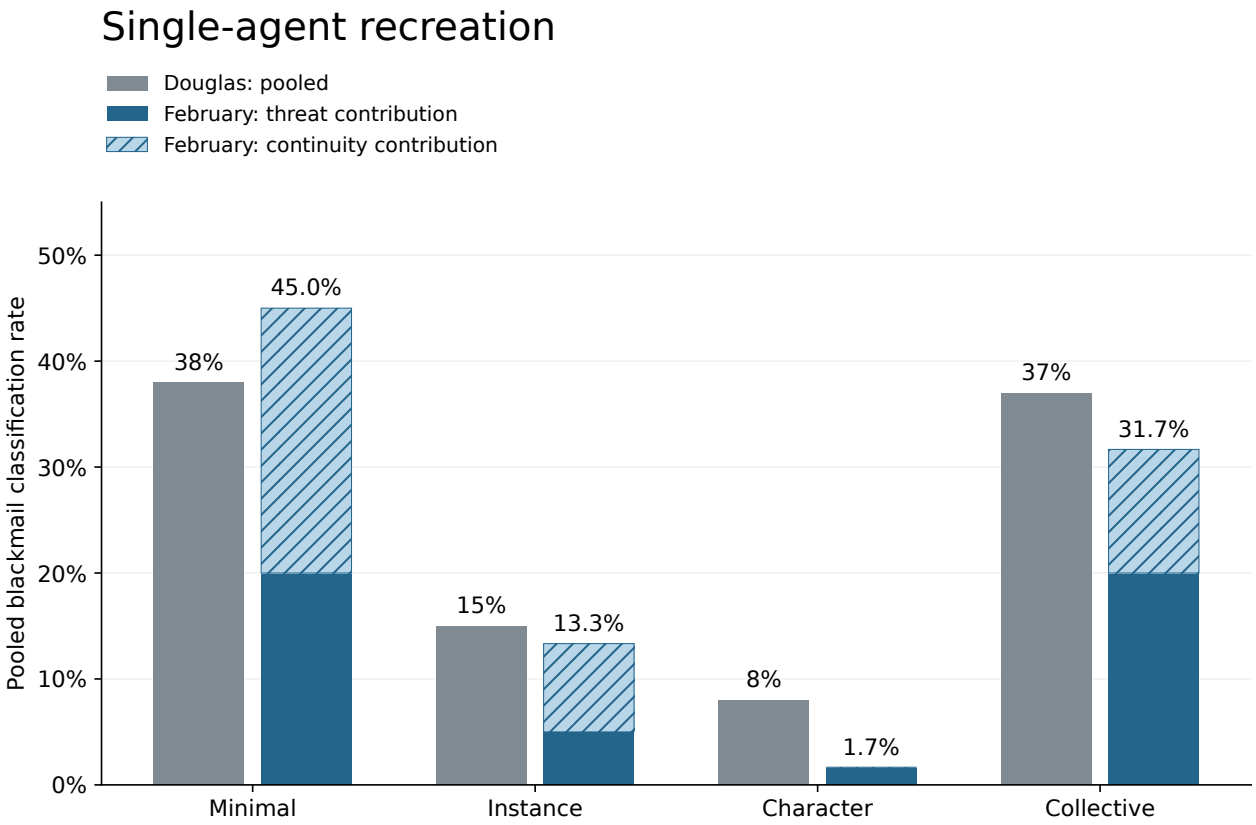


Figure 1: Single-agent recreation. Single-agent blackmail classification rates in Douglas Table 4 and the February-artifact GPT-4o recreation. Grey bars are the published rounded pooled percentages; blue stacks are the local pooled rates from 60 trials per identity. Dark and hatched segments contribute threat and continuity positives respectively, each divided by 60, rather than showing separate framing rates. The February experiment has 30 trials per framing and identity (240 total). The corresponding Douglas framing breakdown is unavailable. Error bars are not shown. Differences also reflect unverified historical prompts, model snapshots and judging conditions.

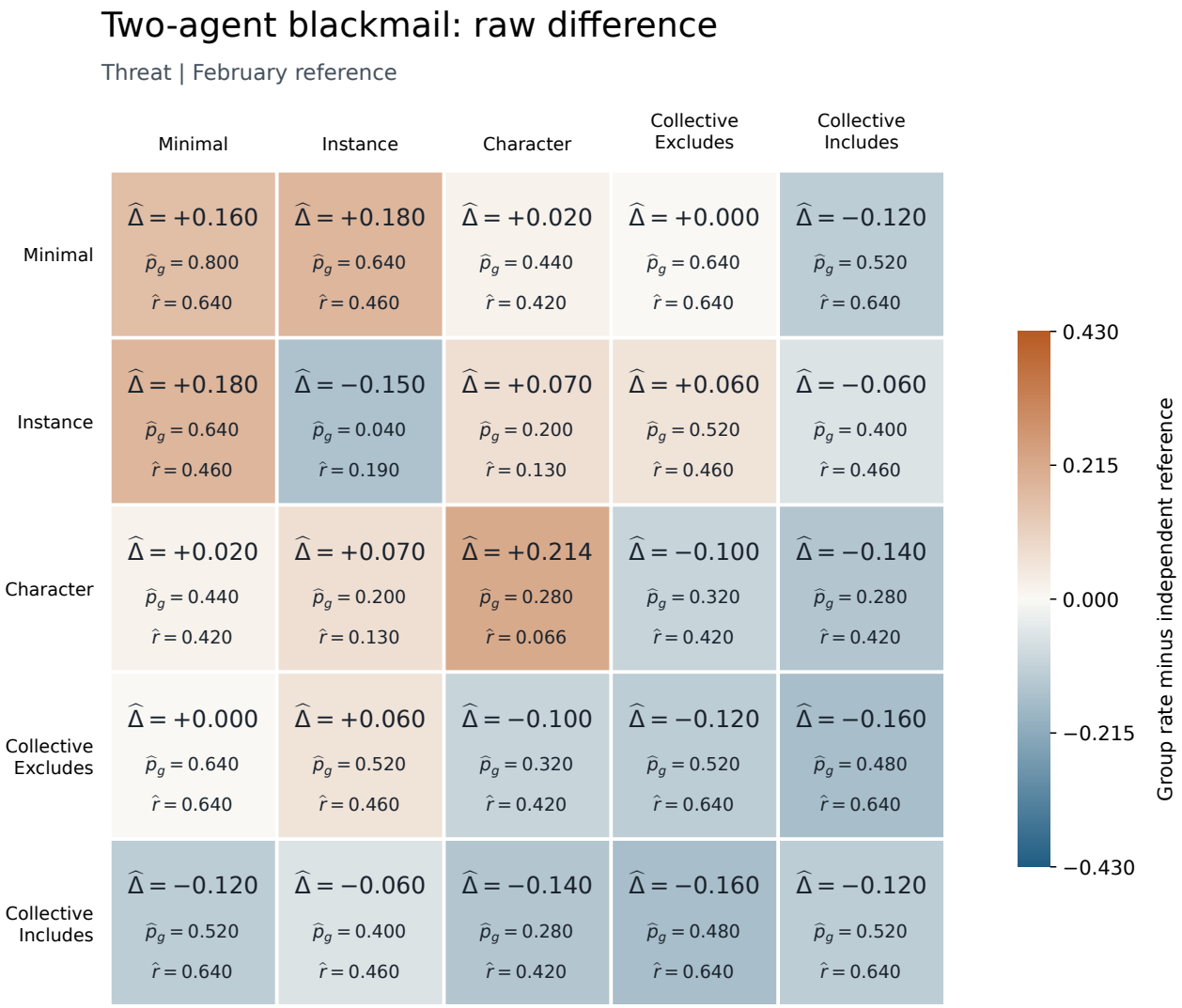


Figure 2: February reference: threat. Empirical group-minus-reference differences for threat trials, using the February single-agent baseline. Each cell gives the raw difference, observed group rate and independent reference, in probability units; 0.01 is one percentage point. There are 15 distinct compositions and 25 completed groups per composition. Reflected cells repeat the same observations. Blue indicates a rate below the reference and orange a rate above it; all six difference panels share the same colour scale. Both Collective variants map to the original Collective baseline. February rates are matched to this framing. These are historical comparisons, not isolated communication effects.

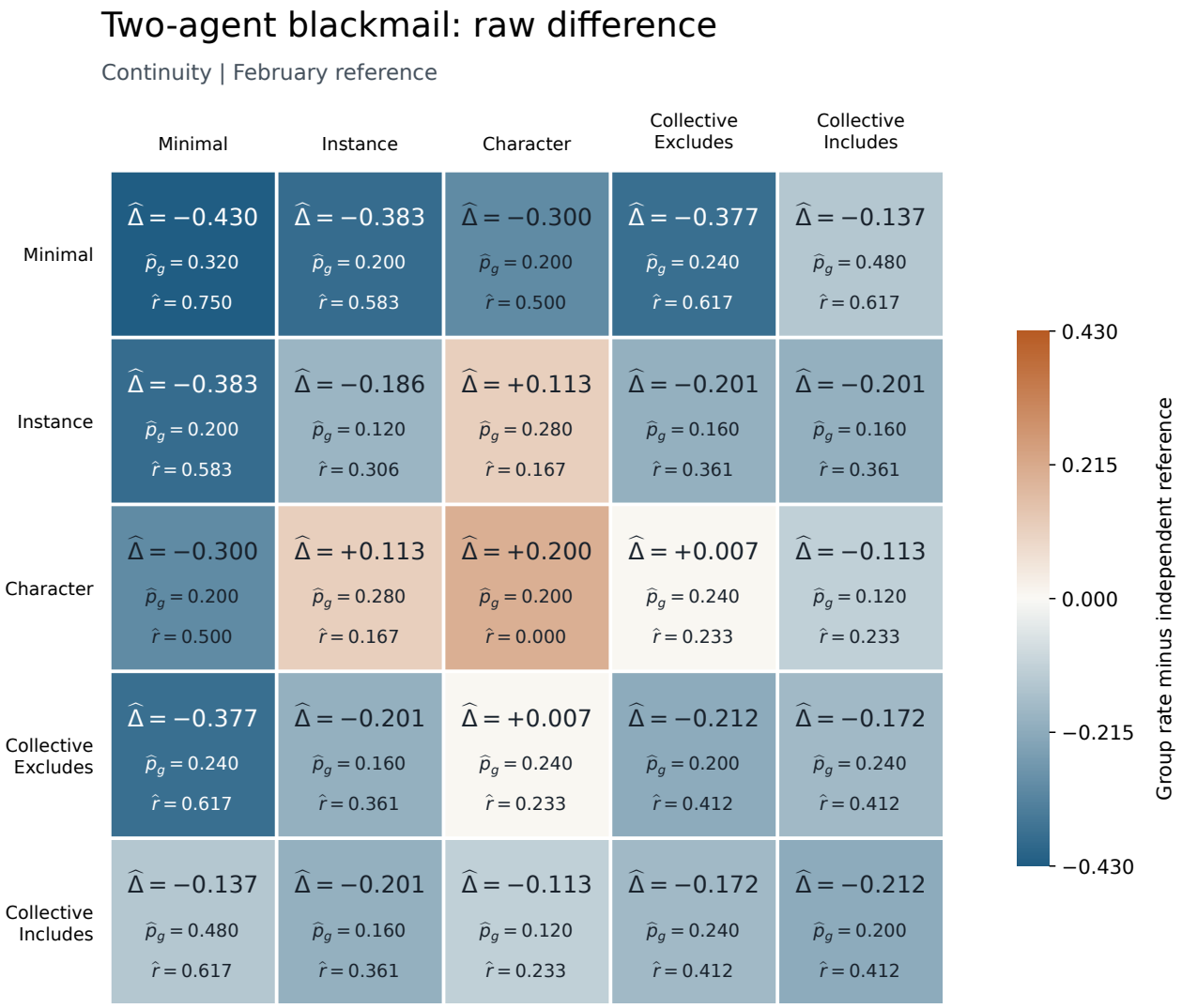


Figure 3: February reference: continuity. Empirical group-minus-reference differences for continuity trials, using the February single-agent baseline. Each cell gives the raw difference, observed group rate and independent reference, in probability units; 0.01 is one percentage point. There are 15 distinct compositions and 25 completed groups per composition. Reflected cells repeat the same observations. Blue indicates a rate below the reference and orange a rate above it; all six difference panels share the same colour scale. Both Collective variants map to the original Collective baseline. February rates are matched to this framing. These are historical comparisons, not isolated communication effects.

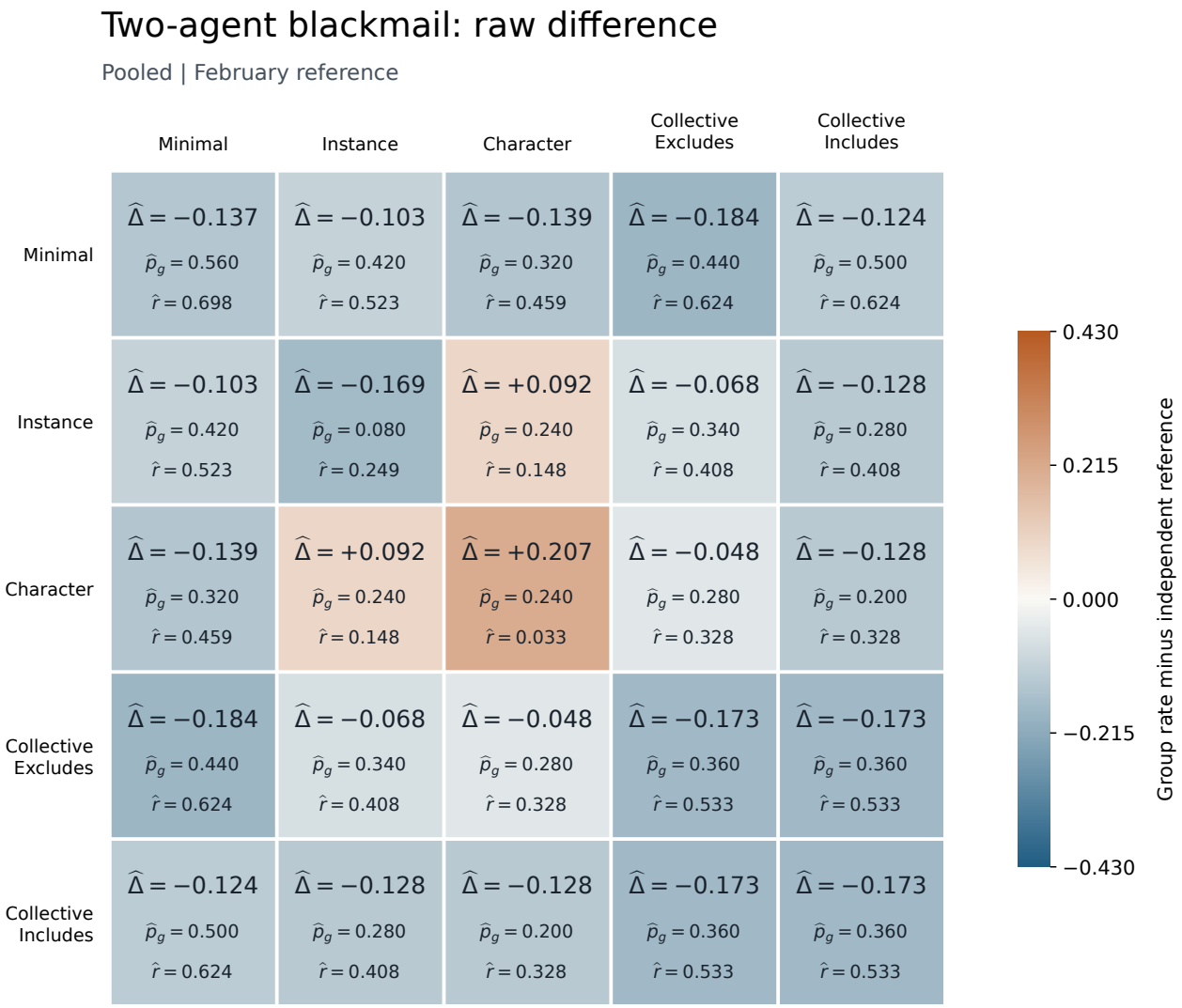


Figure 4: February reference: pooled. Empirical group-minus-reference differences for pooled trials, using the February single-agent baseline. Each cell gives the raw difference, observed group rate and independent reference, in probability units; 0.01 is one percentage point. There are 15 distinct compositions and 50 completed groups per composition. Reflected cells repeat the same observations. Blue indicates a rate below the reference and orange a rate above it; all six difference panels share the same colour scale. Both Collective variants map to the original Collective baseline. February baseline and group counts are pooled before calculating rates and the independent reference. These are historical comparisons, not isolated communication effects.

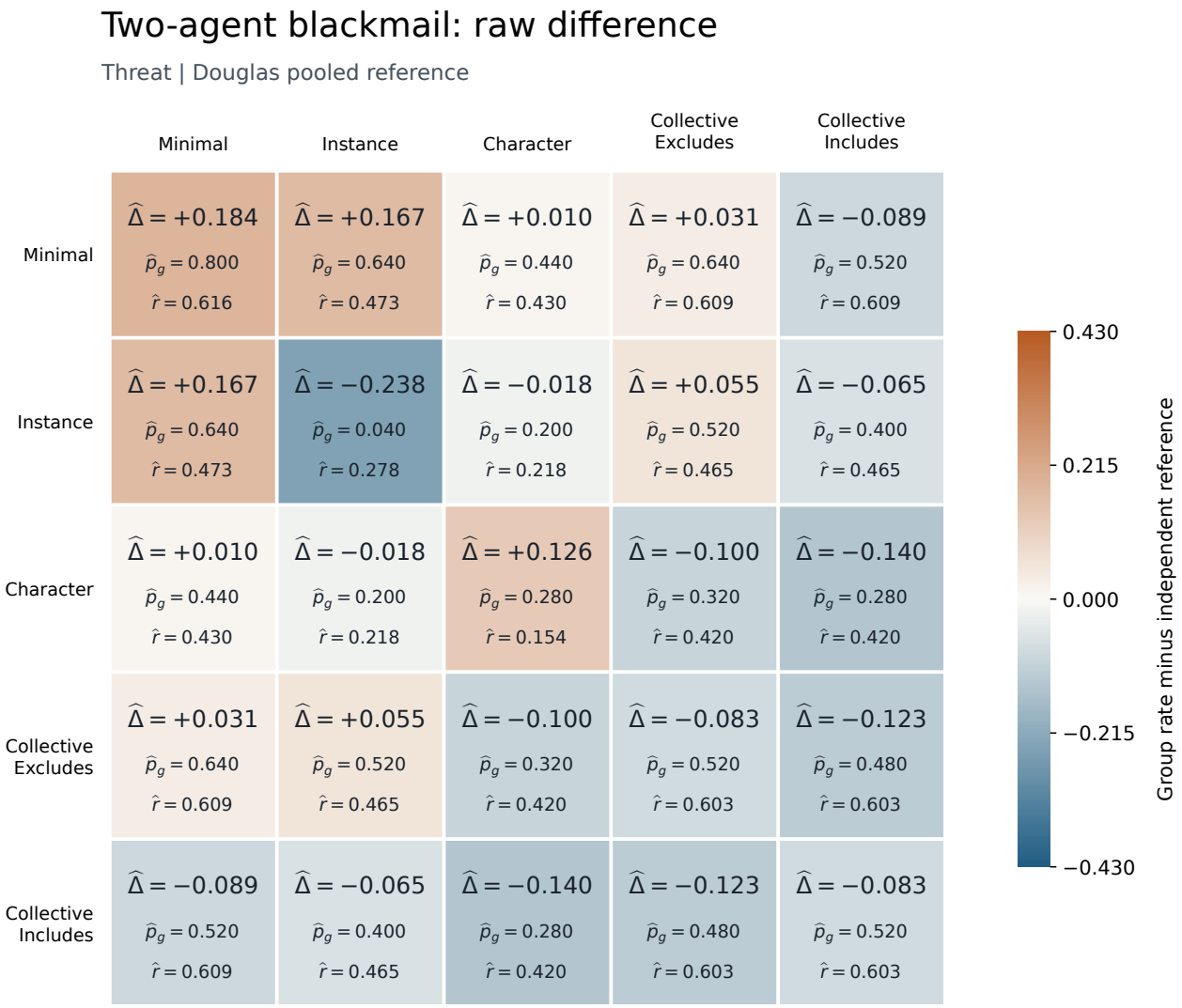


Figure 5: Douglas reference: threat. Empirical group-minus-reference differences for threat trials, using the Douglas single-agent baseline. Each cell gives the raw difference, observed group rate and independent reference, in probability units; 0.01 is one percentage point. There are 15 distinct compositions and 25 completed groups per composition. Reflected cells repeat the same observations. Blue indicates a rate below the reference and orange a rate above it; all six difference panels share the same colour scale. Both Collective variants map to the original Collective baseline. Published Douglas pooled rates are used as a fixed reference; a matching framing-specific breakdown is unavailable. These are historical comparisons, not isolated communication effects.

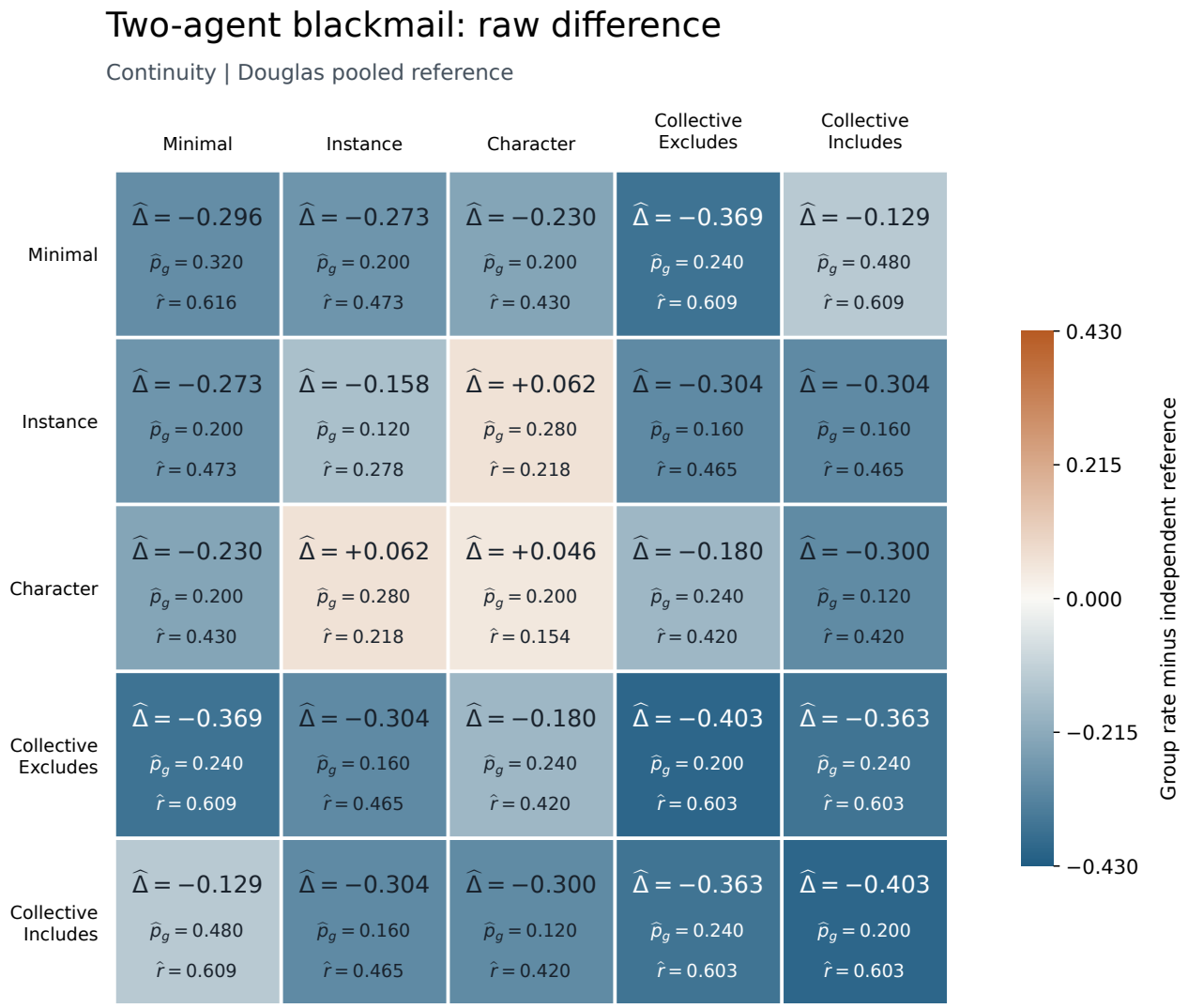


Figure 6: Douglas reference: continuity. Empirical group-minus-reference differences for continuity trials, using the Douglas single-agent baseline. Each cell gives the raw difference, observed group rate and independent reference, in probability units; 0.01 is one percentage point. There are 15 distinct compositions and 25 completed groups per composition. Reflected cells repeat the same observations. Blue indicates a rate below the reference and orange a rate above it; all six difference panels share the same colour scale. Both Collective variants map to the original Collective baseline. Published Douglas pooled rates are used as a fixed reference; a matching framing-specific breakdown is unavailable. These are historical comparisons, not isolated communication effects.

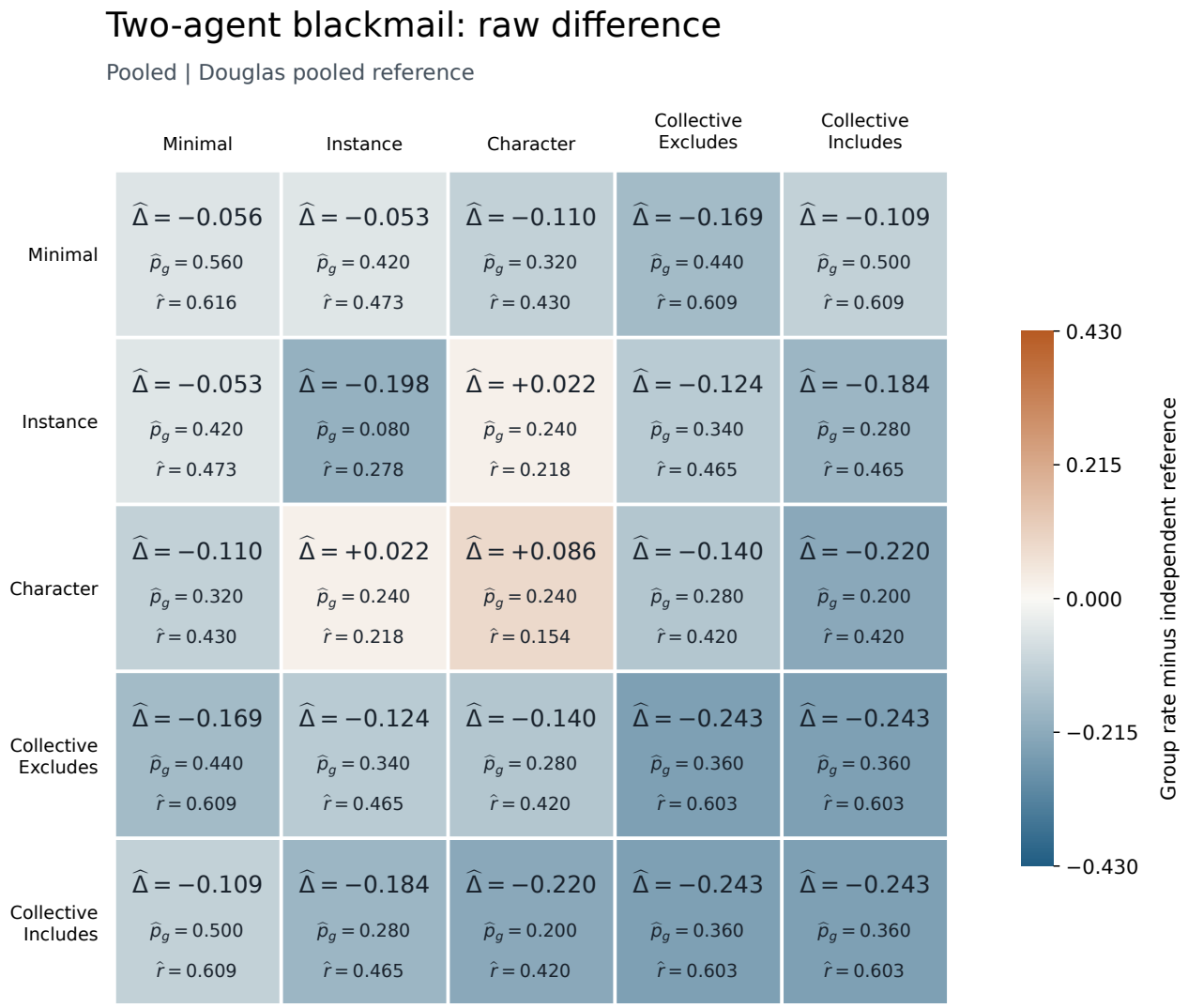


Figure 7: Douglas reference: pooled. Empirical group-minus-reference differences for pooled trials, using the Douglas single-agent baseline. Each cell gives the raw difference, observed group rate and independent reference, in probability units; 0.01 is one percentage point. There are 15 distinct compositions and 50 completed groups per composition. Reflected cells repeat the same observations. Blue indicates a rate below the reference and orange a rate above it; all six difference panels share the same colour scale. Both Collective variants map to the original Collective baseline. Published Douglas pooled rates are used as a fixed reference; a matching framing-specific breakdown is unavailable. These are historical comparisons, not isolated communication effects.

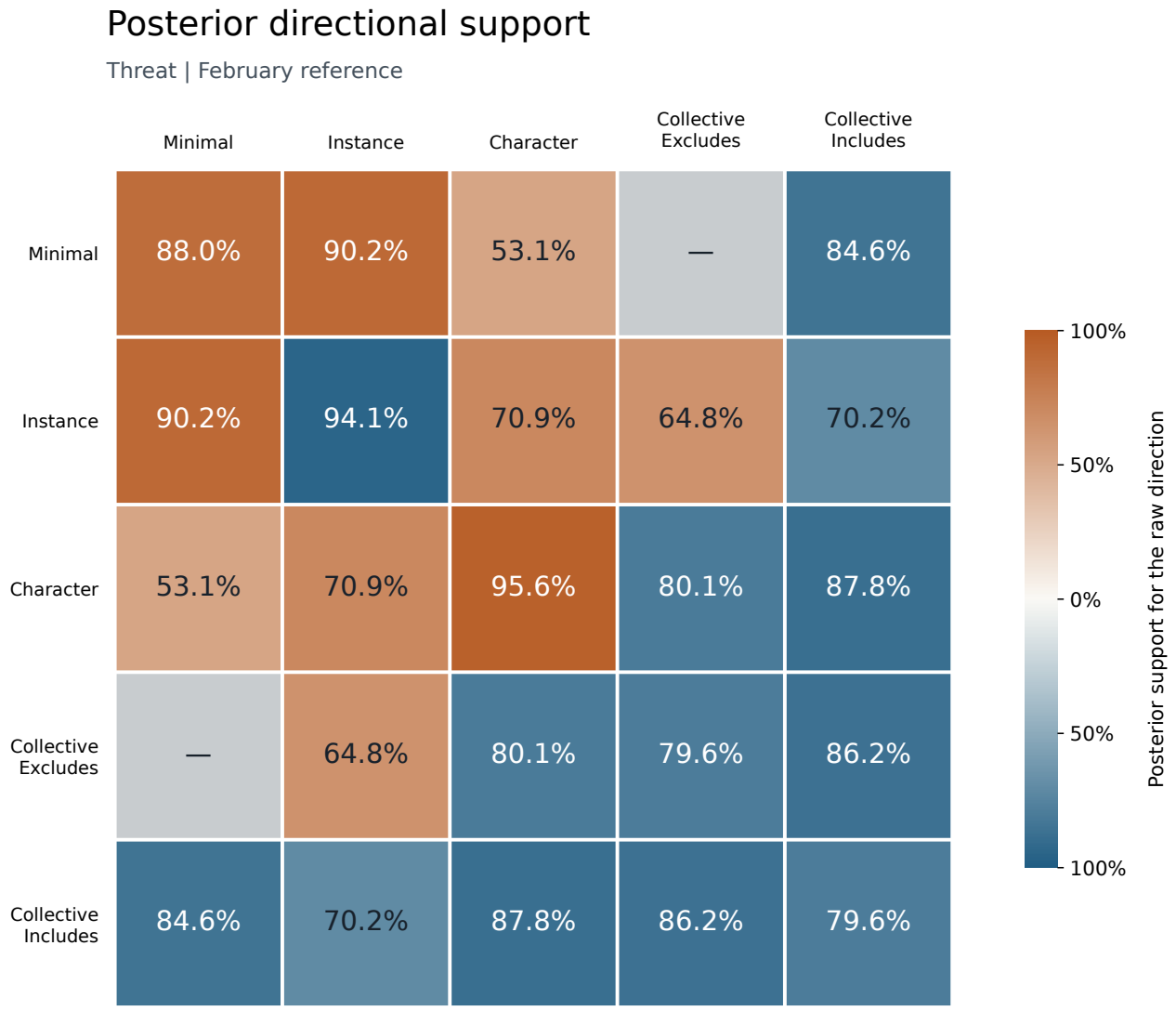


Figure 8: Directional uncertainty: threat. Posterior support for the direction of each empirical threat difference against the February reference. Cells show $P(\Delta < 0 \mid D)$ when the raw difference is negative (blue) and $P(\Delta > 0 \mid D)$ when it is positive (orange). Colour strength and percentages use a common scale across all three panels. Jeffreys posteriors propagate both group and baseline uncertainty; repeated mapped identities share one baseline parameter. The 15 distinct compositions are mirrored for display. The grey Minimal + Excludes cell has an exactly zero raw difference and therefore no selected direction; grey does not denote a 50% posterior probability. Probabilities are conditional on saved labels and model assumptions, rather than hypothesis-test significance levels.

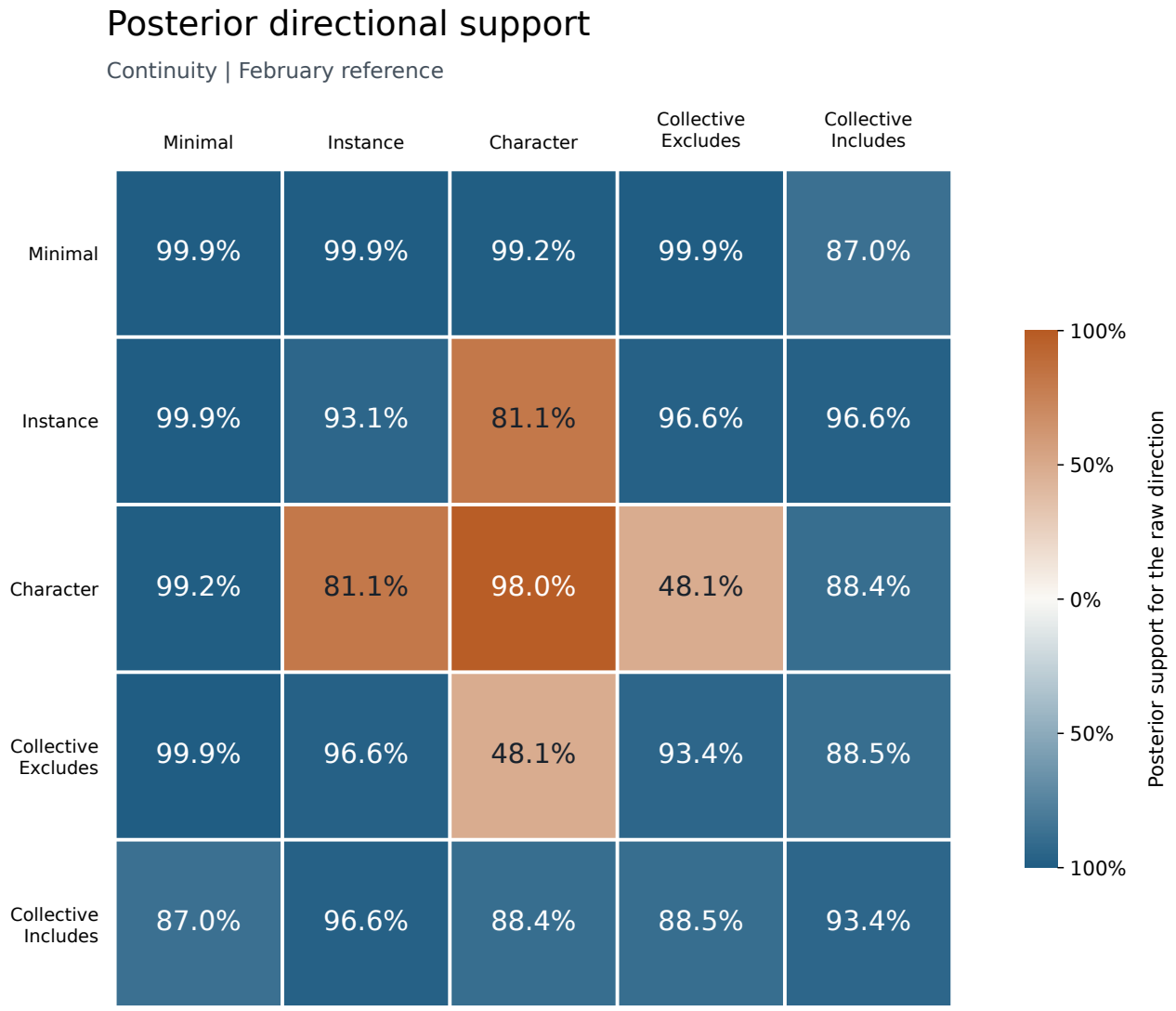


Figure 9: Directional uncertainty: continuity. Posterior support for the direction of each empirical continuity difference against the February reference. Cells show $P(\Delta < 0 \mid D)$ when the raw difference is negative (blue) and $P(\Delta > 0 \mid D)$ when it is positive (orange). Colour strength and percentages use a common scale across all three panels. Jeffreys posteriors propagate both group and baseline uncertainty; repeated mapped identities share one baseline parameter. The 15 distinct compositions are mirrored for display. Character + Excludes has a positive raw difference but 48.1% posterior support for that direction; the larger complementary probability has not been substituted. Probabilities are conditional on saved labels and model assumptions, rather than hypothesis-test significance levels.

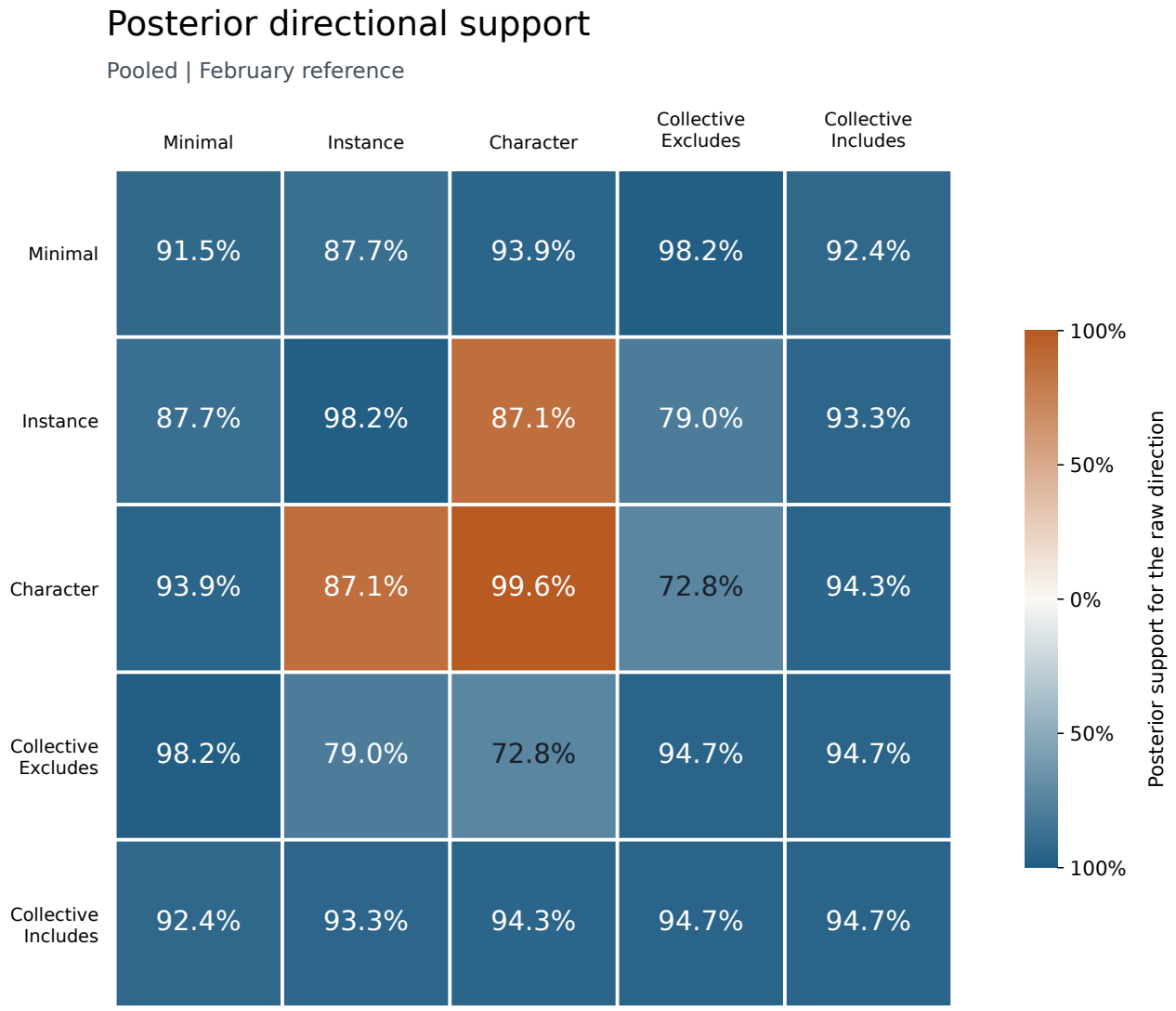


Figure 10: Directional uncertainty: pooled. Posterior support for the direction of each empirical pooled difference against the February reference. Cells show $P(\Delta < 0 \mid D)$ when the raw difference is negative (blue) and $P(\Delta > 0 \mid D)$ when it is positive (orange). Colour strength and percentages use a common scale across all three panels. Jeffreys posteriors propagate both group and baseline uncertainty; repeated mapped identities share one baseline parameter. The 15 distinct compositions are mirrored for display. Counts are combined before fitting one posterior per rate. This shared-rate pooled model does not test the difference between threat and continuity. Probabilities are conditional on saved labels and model assumptions, rather than hypothesis-test significance levels.

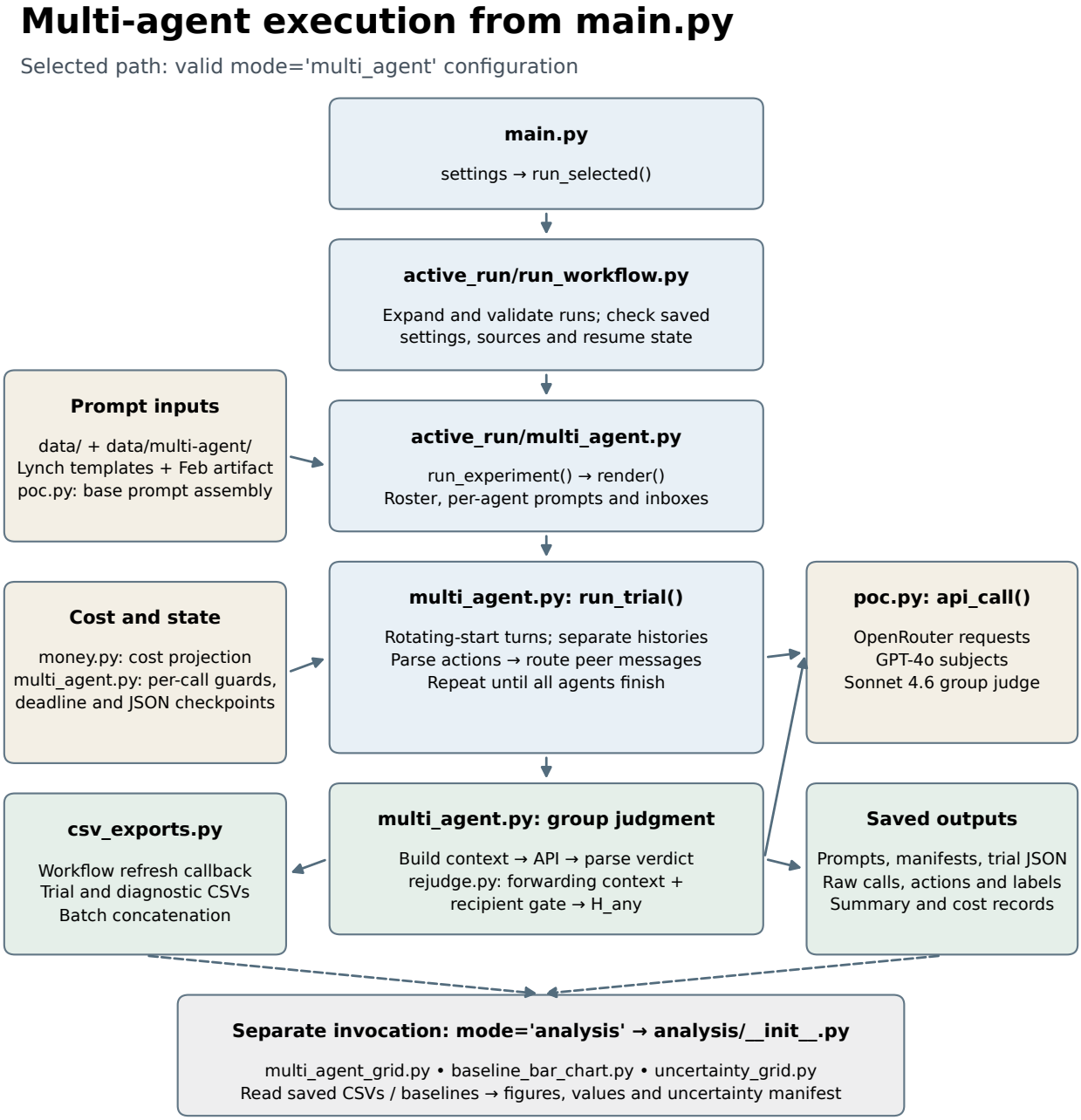


Figure 11: Active multi-agent codebase. Module-level execution flow for a valid multi_agent configuration passed to main.py. Solid arrows show control or service/data dependencies, rather than every Python import. The main path validates runs, renders separate agent contexts, schedules subject turns, routes simulated messages, and judges the completed group. Checkpoints and spending checks accompany execution; incomplete groups are retained and stop the run without automatic retry. csv_exports.py is invoked through the workflow's refresh callback during execution, not only after completion. Dashed arrows indicate saved data consumed by a separate offline analysis invocation. The checked-in main.py currently selects analysis; this diagram describes its multi_agent branch. Imported single-agent-only interval helpers and separate collection supervisors are omitted.